It's a complex challenge therefore for Yogi—in a way reflective of a generational change Uttar Pradesh itself is straining to make. The chief minister has been trying to sync with this by repositioning the state as an investment destination—for which the crackdown on the mafia is an essential precondition—and also adopting a more inclusive approach to governance. Last July, responding to the controversy over *azaan* at mosques, he ordered loudspeakers removed (or their volumes lowered) from all religious places. Loudspeakers were removed from thousands of temples, mosques et al—even his own Gorakhnath temple's loudspeakers toned down its decibels. And during Ramnavami and Hanuman Jayanti last year, many other states reported violence but strict permission norms and prior affidavits to maintain peace meant Uttar Pradesh offered itself as an unlikely continent of calm. "As many as 800 Ramnavami rallies were held in this state of 250 million people, and it was Ramzan too. Not a single incident was reported," claims an official in the chief minister's office.

The crackdown has had perceptible effects on the ground—many among the common citizenry attest to a change in the general air of security. And old niches of crime, like the auto-theft syndicate of Meerut, have been busted. The bulldozer has loomed as an essential component of this, but is still bracketed as a less-than-kosher instrument of justice. Yogi's critics say it often fails to discriminate between a mafioso's mansion and a political target—the overnight demolition of the Prayagraj house of Delhi University student activist Afreen Fatima, on the charge that her 56-year-old social activist father was a 'mastermind of riots', is an example they cite. And when Pramila Dikshit and daughter Neha were charred to death during a demolition drive in Kanpur this February, the bulldozer came to be talked of more commonly as a symbol of overreach.

The Yogi administration has added an interesting Robin Hood-like gesture to soften its tactics, building low-cost housing on cleared sites, but it still constitutes an extra-judicial punitive measure with no sanction within law and has had the courts looking askance at it. Describing the right to housing/shelter as a fundamental right upheld by the Supreme Court, senior Allahabad High court lawyer Syed Farman Ahmad Naqvi says "the thin line between democracy and despotism" must not be crossed. Senior advocate I.B. Singh concurs on how due process can be abused via a narrow definition: "A lot of the action against the mafia was legal, and hence upheld by the courts. But there are question marks about the property-seizing spree. Over 50 per cent of old buildings in Lucknow do not have correct maps, so all are vulnerable. Where will people go?"

The BJP always has well-tailored answers down pat, but this may be territory where listening to criticism could actually serve them well. SP spokesperson Sunil Singh



"Now professional criminals or mafia cannot threaten anybody... Earlier, the state faced a crisis of identity; now criminals face a crisis in the state. There have been no riots in the past six years. The rule of law prevails"

–YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

"Our actions are religion-neutral, region-neutral and caste-neutral. We have gone after all the criminals"

–PRASHANT KUMAR
ADG, Law & Order, UP Police

